



SHAILESH RAVAL

IN CONTROL: Sonia

And now, partymen too eager to look for an occasion to praise their "first family" have begun felicitating her a week before the one-decade milestone. Even the party's parliamentary party meeting for the Budget session ended on a note of congratulations for their now rather experienced party president. The bouquets and sloganeering followed later.

Sonia has indeed come a long way. She took charge of her party after 1998 election debacle when it got only 141 seats. The Congress is still short of the halfway mark but it is in power, and the dynasty is back on track. Of course, her charm for the Congress lies not in just what she has done for the party but also the hope she offers for the future—grooming heir apparent, Rahul Gandhi.

by Priya Sahgal

Standing the Test of Time

DELHI It has been quite an eventful decade for Sonia Gandhi. She is now in her eleventh year of being the Congress president. Ten years ago, in a well-choreographed Congress Working Committee (cwc) meeting held on March 14, 1998, the then presi-

dent Sitaram Kesri was removed with the help of a loophole in the party constitution (discovered by Pranab Mukherjee). This gave cwc members extraordinary powers to overrule the president. Needless to add, this loophole has never been used

since! Kesri then had deemed it illegal and it was Sonia who persuaded him to come around. That was her first step as the chief firefighter for the Congress. More recently she has been practising her placating skills on the Communists.

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Farmers in Bihar's Chapra district who took to sugarcane farming after the promise of a sugar factory there are now livid: there are no signs of the factory and no signs of a former Union minister who promised and failed to deliver.

VOICES

"I urge the Bhishma Pitamah (grand old man) of Indian politics, Sri Atal Bihari Vajpayee, to listen to his conscience and let national interest prevail."

Manmohan Singh, prime minister

"I don't spend my time thinking about it (being prime minister). At present, it's my endeavour to run the Youth Congress democratically."

Rahul Gandhi, Congress leader

"You welcome migrants when their labour and skills are needed. But once economic growth is achieved, you turn them into hate figures. Is this fair?"

Nitish Kumar, Bihar chief minister

"If I were a fox in public life, I would have survived a full term of five years as prime minister. I do not have good relations with the media, which projects me in a poor light."

H.D. Deve Gowda, JD(S) patriarch

"If the Indian Government cannot provide railway connectivity to Arunachal Pradesh, the House should allow the state government to secure a rail connection from China."

Tapir Gao, BJP MP